

AP PHOTO/ROBERTO CANDIA



War Amidst Peace

DELHI With a crew of over 5,000, nearly 80 aircraft and displacing over one lakh tonne, the US supercarrier *USS Nimitz* is a floating island. Berthing off Chennai on July 3, it nearly ran into another island, a metaphorical one—the Indian Left. Foaming-at-the-mouth partymen, trade unionists and nuclear peaceniks termed the five-day visit of the *Nimitz* as evidence of “gunboat diplomacy” and of India becoming a military ally of the United States.

These protests, which would have warmed the hearts of Cubans and

North Koreans, were last seen when the US and IAF aircraft conducted air exercises in the skies over West Bengal.

Even as AIADMK supremo J. Jayalalithaa and MDMK's Vaiko joined the chorus, the Left staged protests and rallies triggering alarms about a possible nuclear fallout which would have led a casual observer believe the Chernobyl power plant had berthed four nautical miles off Chennai.

Initially, it was questions about the warship's nuclear propulsion, never mind that over 5,000

EYE OF A STORM: The *USS Nimitz* docks off Chennai

crewmembers have lived on the 32-year-old ship without any complaints or the US has an enviable track record of 56 accident-free years of nuclear reactor technology.

Then, the Left took umbrage over the US ambiguity over whether or not it carried nuclear weapons on board. The US personnel onboard the *Nimitz* invoked standard policy directives to ‘neither confirm nor deny the presence of nuclear weapons’ on board. The Left saw this as contrary to the Government and the US Embassy's statement that the vessel did not carry nukes.

While the fracas raged on, thousands of *Nimitz* sailors disembarked on shore after a month-long deployment and busied themselves in community service, visiting schools and orphanages and spending time with Tsunami-affected people of Tamil Nadu. Goodwill, clearly seems to be the only fallout of this nuclear warship's visit.

by Sandeep Unnithan

SIGNPOSTS

LISTED: Wipro Technologies' chairman and CEO, **Azim Premji**, among the all-time top 30 entrepreneurs in the world, by business magazine *Business Week*.



DIED: Former Delhi chief minister and BJP vice-president **Sahib Singh Verma**, in

a road accident in Rajasthan's Alwar district. He was a former Union minister and a Lok Sabha member from Outer Delhi constituency from 1999 to 2004.

ISSUED: To three-month-old **Ayush Ranjan Rout**, a permanent account number (PAN) on the grounds that he was a paid model and needed to file his returns. He is the youngest Indian to hold a PAN card.

APPOINTED: Professor **Mahendra P. Lama** of the School of International Studies, Jawaharal Nehru University, Delhi, as the first vice-chancellor of Sikkim University.

VIS-A-VIS **M. KARUNANIDHI** Tamil Nadu chief minister **versus** **J. JAYALALITHAA** AIADMK chief

“
Her statements are a bundle of contradictions. Where did she get crores of rupees to acquire partnership in the estate?
”



SAURABH SINGH

“
It's not illegal to run a tea estate and build a house there to reside in. He is hurling false allegations at me.
”

EPILOGUE: Mysterious acquisition of crores is a charge many politicians can be accused of.